



CHIDAMBARAM ADDRESSES A PRESS CONFERENCE WITH OMAR

The Call of the VALLEY

The Centre rolls out a rehabilitation policy for Kashmiri youth who had crossed over to PoK but gaps remain

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

If the matter weren't so serious, the impending talks between India and Pakistan could be the nearest thing to a dialogue of the deaf where both sides do not want to hear, much less address the problems raised by the other. While Pakistan wants to talk about Kashmir, India does not. So New Delhi is quietly working to remove the reason for talks. The Government has evolved a strategy to remove the sense of alienation which has been driving Kashmiri youth to take up the gun.

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) calls it a strategy to win the hearts and minds of the people. The latest effort

in this psychological war is the policy on surrender and rehabilitation of youth who had crossed over to Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) for training in militant camps. When the suggestion came from Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) Chief Minister Omar Abdullah earlier this month, Home Minister P. Chidambaram was quick to respond positively. The state Government was getting feelers from the families of many youth—some as young as 16—to facilitate their return. Clearing the way, Chidambaram said that they were welcome to come back since PoK was anyway a part of India. He grabbed it as an opportunity to make a point to Pakistan before the proposed foreign secretary level talks

between the two countries.

Home Secretary G. K. Pillai said that MHA and the state Government were jointly working on the blueprint of the policy, which should be ready by March-end. Sources, however, said that something as sensitive as this should not be done in a hurry. "When these youth agreed to go across, it was obviously because they were convinced by a certain ideology. The Government must find a way of ensuring that they have the right reasons to return," warned former Intelligence Bureau chief A.K. Doval.

Home Ministry sources said that everything will be taken into account before the policy is finalised. It will include intense debriefing, involving families and providing employment opportunities, not merely to make them eyes and ears of intelligence outfits. Only then a general amnesty would be offered. But experts foresee a problem with regards to those who had surrendered earlier. Would the amnesty be extended to them too? And what about those who are wanted for terror related activity in India? Will they be tried for their crimes or offered amnesty? "These are questions that the Government will have to take into account while finalising the policy. In principle, it appears to be a good thing," said Doval.

"If there is a policy in place, at least the Government and intelligence agencies will be able to keep tabs on them, though not in an oppressive manner," said a Home Ministry official. According to estimated figures of state Government, at least 20 young men returned in 2008, as many as 63 in 2009, and three have already returned this year (See box).

However, Chidambaram may not find it easy to implement the policy due to opposition from within his party. Former J&K chief minister Ghulam Nabi Azad expressed reservations, saying it would be difficult to monitor people who return in the garb of re-

Families want the Government to facilitate the return of their men